OUT OF THIS WORLD



Photographs by BANDEEP SINGH

THOUGHT SESSION | The New Age of Travel

PLUG AND FLY: On Mars landings. And inventing electric planes on Earth. From a woman on the frontlines of both

ANITA SENGUPTA
Former NASA scientist, aerospace entrepreneur

A pilot, an aerospace engineer, and a rocket scientist, Anita Sengupta is all that and much more. While speaking at the India Today Conclave, she touched upon the subjects of space missions, Mars landings, planes of the future, and the new age of travel based on the concept of plug and fly.

"It's in the nature of humanity to explore and push the envelope," she said. And the next phase is exploring space. "It's natural for us to expand as a species and one of the easiest places to get to and set up a colony is Mars," she added. On the chances of finding life beyond Earth, Sengupta believes that "we are not alone in the universe".

About her newest venture—hydroplane—researching hydrogen fuel cells for light helicopters that are emission-free, she said, "We are going to have our first flight this year and it not only supports aircraft and helicopters but also vehicles operating on diesel. It has the ability to decarbonise ground transport." On scaling up the technology, which has the potential to revolutionise mobility with clean and cheaper fuel, she said, "We are starting small to get the product sooner into the market." ■

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Hydrogen fuel cell technology was developed for the space programme and is an efficient form of energy storage for others
- Jupiter's moon Europa has a liquid water ocean. Sengupta feels that when we send something to nail through the ice, we will find some form of lifeform. It will not be intelligent like us, but it will be an organism and that will change our perspective

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> **An engineering degree is the best you can get. It teaches you how to think and solve problems. With that, you can do anything**